

It is almost twenty centuries since Sigmar Heldenhammer purged from our lands the monstrous hordes that dwelt there. So was founded the greatest of all the realms of men – the Empire. Today our thoughts turn once more to Sigmar, the God of Battles: Sigmar, the Father of Men, as the millennium turns and the time of his second coming approaches. In temples throughout our land the multitudes gather to bear of the many and wondrous events that will surely unfold upon the return to his people of the living god.

The Chronicler of Ostermark - entry for the year 1999

Never is the Father of Men more sorely needed than in the dying year of the last century of the second millennium. For the Empire, once as mighty in arms as it was bold in spirit, is now a realm rent by war and weakened by corruption. No Emperor rules in these dark and terrible days, instead the Empire is riven into many lands, from Ostermark in the cold north to Wissenland in the distant south, from Marienburg by the Western Ocean to Sylvania that lies under the shadow of the Worlds Edge Mountains. Each lord fights his brothers within his borders and his neighbours without. Thus the lords of the Empire squabble over the crown whilst bandits and rogues roam at will.

None suffer as greatly as the dispossessed, so it is scarce wonder that the poor give themselves to wantonness, drunkenness and all manner of vice. Theirs is aretched existence: slain by blade and fire, squeezed dry by tax gatherers, and robbed by bloated merchants who grow ever richer upon the profits of disorder.

It was in the city of
Mordheim, in the land of
Ostermark, on the first
day of the year
nineteen

hundred and ninety nine of the era of Sigmat that the Seeress of the Sisters of Sigmar first observed in the night sky the long awaited sign. It was as the prophet Macadamnus of Greill had predicted more than five hundred years before when he wrote:

In the city of his sisters he will return to us on wings of fire.

From his throne be shall reign in incorruptible flesh forever:

No death shall there be for those that gather to him there.

And the northern lords shall rule the lands of the world together.

The Cantos of Macadamnus - Verse CXXXI

Only then was it clear that the city referred to was none other than Mordheim. This city was home to the Holy Order of the Sisters of Sigmar, the 'sisters' of the prophesy, and also the most northerly of the lands of the Empire. As to the 'wings of fire', this meaning too was plain for all to see. Overhead in the night sky was Sigmar's own holy sign, the double-tailed comet whose appearance two thousand years before was held to have foretold of his birth. Night after night the comet grew brighter. Day after day people flooded into Mordheim as news spread through the Empire of Sigmar's impending descent upon wings of fire.

As that last year of the twentieth century wore on, the comet swelled until the night was altogether banished from the streets of Mordheim. Its fires raged in the heavens so that the sun itself seemed a dull cold thing in comparison. Beneath that portentous orb the people of Mordheim seemed to forget any sense of modesty and gave themselves up to a ceaseless orgy of depravity. Who knows how many souls were crammed into that city? How many hundreds of thousands had gathered there from all over the Empire so that every

street of every district overflowed with the unceasing music of merrymaking. Outside the city walls the newcomers heaved and crushed and danced. None sought rest or shelter – for in those endless days no-one stopped to sleep but danced, feasted, drank and gave themselves up to indecent pleasures. Later, it is said that Daemons crept from the shadows and mingled with the throng, crying joyously and cavorting with man and woman alike. But who can be sure of anything that happened, their minds clouded ever afterwards by the horror of those times.

Thus was gathered into Mordheim on the eve of its destruction all the sins of men together, as a boil gathers the poisons of the body ready to be lanced by the surgeon's knife.

Bernhardt Hal - Witch Hunter General

It was not Sigmar but his judgement that fell upon the city of Mordheim on the first moment of the first day of the new era. As the cavalcade of wickedness reached its zenith the Hammer of Sigmar fell to earth and ended forever the lives of every man, woman and child within the city. With a roar ten thousand times louder than thunder the ground seemed to rise to meet the fire, casting down buildings, toppling walls and flattening trees in a flaming blast. In the distant city of Altdorf temples shuddered and falling masonry plummeted to the streets below. Far beyond the Empire's borders the underground fortresses of the Dwarfs, that had stood for generations, cracked and fell.

Nothing remained of Mordheim but burned and charred ruins. The city was so crowded that not everyone could enter, and a few of the revellers that massed outside the city walls did avoid the cataclysm. These survivors fled as far as they could, carrying the tale of Sigmar's divine punishment throughout the Empire. But even these did not escape unharmed – for many subsequently died, their bodies twisted and distorted from within by mutation and their minds tortured by the memories of what they had witnessed.

A pall of smoke hung over the ruin for seven days and seven nights, and a great heat burned as a glowing coal from the furnace of the netherworld.

*The Chronicler of Ostermark
– entry for the year 2000*

Swirling vapour enshrouded the city for many days after its destruction. This miasma was lit from within by an unearthly green glow and was so hot that none could approach. Eventually, this vapour dispersed somewhat and the ruins cooled. A few of the dispossessed drifted back to make a search for valuables abandoned in haste or such treasures as might have escaped the wrath of Sigmar.

In the new year strange stories began to circulate of a wondrous stone discovered in the ruins – a glowing dark shard capable of working miracles. Soon other stones were discovered, of all shapes and sizes, credited with powers of the most extraordinary kind. If such tales are to be believed the sick were cured, the blind could be made to see, tall trees would grow from the ground in a single day, and the very dead could be raised and made to speak again.

Most telling of all was the successful transmutation of lead to gold – a feat undertaken at the behest of Siegfried, Count of Reikland, by his personal alchemist van Hoffman. Rumours of this discovery spread like wildfire throughout the Empire and beyond as all manner of men flocked to the ruins of Mordheim to search for wyrdstone, as the strange stones were now called.

So it was that the ruins of Mordheim drew the attention of the lords of the Empire and many more besides – for power and wealth was surely there for the taking! For some there was the promise of wealth in the form of gold which would pay their armies and advance their imperial ambitions, for others there was the lure of magical power, yet others were drawn by simple greed or else by more sinister reasons that loyal and goodly men could but hardly imagine.

Then came the reports of monsters that lurked in the ruins, gigantic rats the size of men, the walking-dead, Daemons and mutant creatures that might once have been men. Of such things nothing more is to be said here. All came to Mordheim with their dreams – though few scarce imagined that by their actions the destiny of the world would soon be decided.

***Heaven, Earth and Hell the three
shall be indivisible,
From the serenth toll of the Seven
Emperors' bell.
When the land of Sigmar
burns in flame,
And the dead walk
beside Daemon, beast
and man.***

*The Cantos of
Macadamnus
– Verse CCXXI*

During the year of madness before Mordheim's destruction, Ostermark fell into ever greater ruin as all matters of governance were neglected. Farmlands were abandoned as people flocked to the city, smiths deserted their forges, and even merchants and money lenders gave up all attempt at commerce. Thus even before the devastation, the land of Ostermark had fallen into anarchy and its ruler, Count Steinhardt, had long since embraced the unhealthy pleasures so prevalent in those final days. He, together with most of the nobility of the land, perished in the cleansing fires of Sigmar and sorrowfully there were few who mourned the passing of the ancient and honourable line of Steinhardt.

They flock to Mordheim

Today the land of Ostermark exists in name only. Wild reavers roam freely over lands that are now neglected and ruinous. Foreign armies march through its territory without heed and such honest men who remain, a pitiful few, must endure the constant marauding of thieves and bandits. Yet men still come to Ostermark, indeed they flock there from all over the Empire like carrion to a corpse. They are drawn by the mysterious lure of Wyrdstone, for the magical powers of this stone have made it valuable

beyond its weight in gold. Though the rewards for their endeavours may be great, and many a fortune has been earned in a day, the dangers are greater still.

When treasure seekers first entered Mordheim they did so without care and often singly or in pairs, for little did they imagine the terrors that lurked in the grim ruins of the city. Many vanished without trace. Others returned maimed in body or unseated in mind, babbling uncontrollably of outlandish and bestial creatures. Some talked endlessly of Daemons and creatures from the pit. A few emerged empty-handed from the ruins to laugh insanely and unceasingly to this very day. Soon it was only the most foolhardy who ventured alone into the City of the Damned. Fortune seekers chose instead to gather into armed groups or warbands: all the better for their mutual protection.

Nor was it only monstrous things that were to take the lives of fortune hunters. For the very air of Mordheim was found to be poisonous to those who lingered there too long. Even the Wyrdstone they sought was to prove the death of many – for its raw magical power proved capable of burning flesh and wreaking horrific changes of mind and form. Many who entered Mordheim as comrades were soon driven to discord and murder by the vapours of the air and sorcerous energies of the Wyrdstone. Others needed no magical influence before they set upon their fellows, the very discovery of the valuable stone was enough to make them turn upon each other like savages who dispute a glittering trinket whilst all around them lie even greater treasures. Many more were to emerge from their sorties apparently unharmed, yet they soon sickened and died, or else developed such monstrous deformities of the flesh that their comrades abandoned them to die or else slew them outright to spare their shame.

To enter the gargoyle-guarded gates of that place is to pass through the very gates of death!

Last Words of an Unknown Adventurer

They make their encampment

Because of the pestilence within the city there have grown up beyond its tumbled walls numerous shabby settlements of tents and such rude encampments as parties of hunters build to pass a week in the mountains. Needless to say the great rivalry of men from different lands of the Empire has meant that these are set apart from each other and fortified with crude earthworks against their neighbour's attack. Some, such as Sigmarhaven, are safe enough for all their disorder, mounting paid watchmen to keep the peace and providing a market place for the arms sellers, sutlers and many victuallers whose shoddy wares fetch inflated prices in the treasure-fever camps that gird the ruins. Others, like Cutthroat's Den, are little more than nests of murderers where mutants walk freely and hooded men barter corpses to Necromancers in return for tainted gold.

These refuges, vile as they are, are safe compared with the ruins of Mordheim itself where even to tarry for an idle hour can spell death or worse. The bands of men that dare to venture within are brave indeed or else filled with a desperate kind of madness. Mercenary adventurers find employment quickly in the warbands that sally through the gates of Mordheim each day. Once through that gate, though, all common laws of human conduct cease to have any meaning. One may injure and murder at will and every rival becomes a deadly enemy. Men that might dice and drink together of an evening may find themselves at each others' throats with daggers and swords the

next morning. Such is the law of Mordheim where there are no rules but the natural rule of kill or be killed, for only the strongest are destined to win the greatest prize of all.

The Count of Middenland offers this much gold! The Count of Reikland offers that much more! The Grand Theogonist offers the blessing of Sigmar – though I'd sooner have his gold! Every power in the Empire wants wyrdstone and will do anything to get it... anything except come here and take it for themselves! So – drink up my lads for tomorrow we do their dirty work for 'em and then... we'll make 'em pay!

Fernando Pavaroti, Mercenary Captain

They seek to gain great power

No one emperor reigns over the Empire and none has done so undisputed for four hundred years or more. Amongst the counts of the Empire there are many who would wear the crown had they but the strength to impose their will upon their neighbours. By ancient tradition the Emperor is elected from amongst the rulers of the land, who are known as Electors, so that the aspirant must seek the support of his fellows to obtain the majority. In addition there are other authorities who, whilst not eligible for the crown are also Electors, and these must be courted too for their influence is very great. Most notable is the Grand Theogonist of Sigmar, the leader in spirit of the people of Sigmar, whose temples stand in each town in every part of the Empire.

The discovery of wyrdstone in Mordheim has thrown all into confusion – for it offers an opportunity to break the deadlock between rival claimants. Each count has sponsored mercenary adventurers to recover what wyrdstone they can, Of these the rulers of Reikland, Middenland and Sylvania press hardest for the throne whilst Lady Magritta, the common choice amongst the lesser states and champion of the merchant guilds, has been disqualified by the Grand Theogonist of Sigmar according to the doctrine of male ascent by which no woman may wear Sigmar's crown. Thus it is that the eyes of these great rivals turn towards Mordheim and its uncanny wyrdstone that has the power to turn base metals to gold.

Who is lord in Ostermark? Who is not lord nor Emperor beside for every villain is prince in a land where power lies as eagerly at the foot of rogue, noble & beast.

*The Chronicler of Ostermark
- entry for Midsummer's Day 2000*

The counts are not alone in their greed for power. The Empire has suffered disarray for many hundreds of years and during that time the influence of the merchants and temples has grown greatly. In the city of Marienburg, the largest and most prosperous port in the Old World, merchants have flourished as nowhere else, and today the Burgomeisters of that city wield powers of patronage greater than that of many noble born men. Most influential of all are the Freetraders, a secret circle of the most wealthy guildsmen whose ambition is to raise the Lady Magritta of Marienburg to the throne of the Empire. The citizens of Marienburg are so well known for their richness of dress, love of jewellery and preening ways that there are many who make fun of them and call them 'popinjays'. In truth, there are many more who envy the wealth and security of Marienburg in a time of unrest. As the power of the counts has declined so the power of the merchant guilds has grown apace. Now there are plenty of rich commoners who would like to see an end to the old ways and a new ruling assembly that would give the mercantile classes political authority to match their wealth.

Such is the general discontent that there are some amongst the wealthy who seek to gain power by means most foul! They turn to sorcery, that darkest of arts, recognised by all right-thinking folk as the very embodiment of evil, and whose practice has long since been punished with torture and death. Though few dare say so it is common knowledge that wizards walk abroad in the Empire, meeting secretly to worship dark gods, and creeping amongst the charnel houses to steal the dead. In hidden cellars these agents of corruption summon Demons to do their bidding whilst Necromancers send undead agents into the night to murder and steal. Now it is believed sorcerers walk openly in the City of the Damned, seeking that same wyrdstone whose powers may multiply the vitality of their own dark arts many times over. In consequence the Templars of Sigmar gather to Mordheim, their carts laden with cages, braziers, irons and ingenious instruments of torture, to do the work of Sigmar where it is most sorely needed. Witch Hunters are they called, most commonly by those that fear them and those that hate them, and by themselves too, for they take pride in their persecution of heretics.

The stumps and greasy ashes of the pyres covered the common field as far as the eye could see and the smoke from the witch-fires drifted through the streets. Its stench filled our mouths for days afterwards.

Diary of Selestian Bran

Behind the Witch Hunters stands the greatest spiritual authority in the Empire, the Grand Theogonist of Sigmar. He too dreams of temporal power, having denied the crown to Magritta of Marienburg, he is said to secretly covet it for himself. The destruction of Mordheim has created an atmosphere of religious terror, for who can deny that Sigmar's judgement has come to pass and his people have been found wanting? Since the new year thousands have gathered to the holy places to make peace with their god and accept his punishment. Many supplicants have pledged their goods to the temples and taken to the roads as penance. Great crowds of beggars travel the lands, scourging themselves and each other to atone for the sins of all men. Now the Grand Theogonist has sent his Witch Hunters into Mordheim, ostensibly to cleanse it of the evil that undoubtedly dwells there, but also, it is said, to gather up wyrdstone for his own purposes.

*Crow the black Daemon's brother,
As carrion to corpses gather.
Greed, ambition, guile and hate,
All crowd through fiery gate.
Who now wears Sigmar's crown,
Save be who would be overthrown.*

*Prophesy of Cassandra
– Seeress of the Sisters of Sigmar*

What manner of men
come to Mordheim? What
manner of men do not! To the
tattered encampments that lie
around Mordheim come men from
every state in the Empire, from
Middenheim and the city of Ulric to
Marienburg by the Western Ocean, from
Sylvania and Wissenland and every state between.
Some come for obtuse reasons of their own, but most
come for one purpose only – to make their fortune.
The largest portion of these mercenary adventurers
are hired by the pretenders to the Imperial throne,
the Counts of Middenheim, Marienburg and the
Reikland, three patrons who are by far the richest and

most ambitious contenders for power. Indeed these
three are such bitter rivals that it is rare to find men
from different places even encamped together, and
practically unheard of to find men from one land
fighting in the same warband as men from another.

*As we trod that well beaten track into the
City of the Damned we passed them
banging from the crosses to which they
had been nailed in long procession by the
roadside. We walked then that avenue of
broken corpses whose eyes yet followed us,
whose heads turned as they addressed us
thus in thin, dead words, 'Turn back...
turn back... turn back'.*

f the other claimants to the throne the Count of
Sylvania, Count von Carstein, is the most
powerful but such is his reputation few are tempted
by his gold. For he is said to practice occult heresies
of the most abominable nature, drinking the blood of
men and raising the dead with foul necromancy. His
minions are strange and sly, and though they skulk in
shadow and hide from honest daylight they too can
be found in Mordheim. Few suspect the true nature
of his, save perhaps the Witch Hunters who trust no one,
and for the moment, at least, he remains just another
contender for the throne of Sigmar.

Who knows what ambitions the Grand Theogonist of
Sigmar nurtures for himself? Having refused to crown
the Lady Magritta of Marienburg he has set himself
against the merchant guilds and most notably the
Freetraders of Marienburg whose secret membership
occupies positions of authority throughout the
Empire. Whilst proclaiming a holy crusade against
mutants and sorcerers the Grand Theogonist has sent
the Order of Templars, better known as Witch
Hunters, to scour Mordheim for wyrdstone. His
sermons preach redemption the vengeance of Sigmar,
and the love of the temple, but many suspect
it is earthly rather than spiritual power that he craves.

And what of the thwarted ambitions of the Freetraders
and all those like them to whom the old order and
old ways are shackles and chains binding their desire?
Many have turned to the secret cults of the dark gods
whose worship is the most dire of heresies and to the
practices of sorcery which all nature abhors as the
very stuff of Chaos. Their ambitions drive them

secretly to Mordheim where they gather up the wyrdstone. There they have found a leader, a Dark Emperor, though whether man or Daemon none can say. He is known as the Shadowlord, Master of the Possessed, and is said to dwell within the pit of Mordheim deep inside the crater where the fires of Sigmar's fury still burn hot and foul smoke billows from gaping fissures. From this realm within a realm come daemonic creatures of twisted and malign appearance, things of hideous aspect and great strength, which have come to infest the ruins of the City of the Damned.

Within the city nothing remained as it was but all was utterly devastated, charred and ruinous. Where the hammer blow fell there now stretched a pit the edges of which remained hot to the touch and its sides were as clear and smooth as glass where the very rock had ran molten in the furnace of Sigmar's fury. When the pall lifted from the pit, which took many weeks so thick and noxious were the vapours that rose from it, the curious could discern here and there, as insects trapped in amber, the faces of the dead peering in terror from their glassy tomb, arrayed still as on that fateful night of wantonness and merrymaking.

What too of the Sisters of Sigmar, ancient enemies of the Order of Templars whose fanatical creed denies the divinity of women in Sigmar's temple? Stern and unbending in their views and deaf to reason, the Witch Hunters openly curse them for being heretics and an affront to Sigmar. The Sisterhood themselves are not without power. Their numbers are drawn from the daughters of the noblest houses throughout the Empire. Their cloisters have provided a refuge for many who would otherwise have proven troublesome or embarrassing to their families. These two agencies of Sigmar's will fight side-by-side in Mordheim yet are also the most deadly of enemies, for their rivalry is of an implacable and holy nature which no words of forgiveness can end.

The Sisters of Sigmar hold a unique position in Mordheim for their convent, the Temple of Sigmar's Rock, sits upon a tall and rocky Island midstream in the River Stir which flows through Mordheim dividing it in two. Though the destruction of Mordheim left few buildings standing it is an undoubted miracle that the Temple of Sigmar's Rock and its inhabitants survived unblemished. Indeed, whilst all those about them fell into depravity and wantonness the Sisterhood maintained their holy vigil and raised unending prayer to Sigmar and by this means they escaped his judgement – or so they say, for certainly there are no witnesses to dispute their claims. The

Witch Hunters sneer at these pious claims and maintain instead that a daemonic pact allowed the Sisterhood to betray Mordheim yet escape destruction itself. Even today the Sisters seem blessed, or else favoured by some diabolic power, for the great height of their refuge raises them above the poisonous vapours and they claim to be able to resist the contagion without suffering harm.

And what of those other denizens, the monstrous and the maimed, the mutant and the daemonic in what holes do they dwell and to what ends do they come? These things remain a mystery to this day, yet in time, all mysteries must be revealed. The strange rat-shaped creatures that skitter in the ruins we will cast from our minds for now, as many a bold mercenary adventurer would gladly do if he could, for their story is their own, and for the most part men deny their very existence or else place them amongst the other monstrous and deformed creatures of which there is no shortage in the City of the Damned.

Thus are set the principle players upon the stage of destruction: the mercenary adventurers of Reikland, Middenheim and Marienburg, the undead minions of the vampiric Count von Carstein, the Cult of the Master of the Possessed, the Grand Theogonist's Witch Hunters, the holy Sigmarite Sisters, and most mysterious of all the creatures of the ruins.

